the city's marketplace; Henry himself was waiting there on horseback, ready to receive one-fifth of the slaves as his personal tribute, and perhaps also measuring the success of his dramatic staging. The chronicler Zurara was there as well, watching with his own eyes. "Very early in the morning, by reason of the heat," he writes, "the mariners began to bring-to their vessels, and, as they had been commanded, to draw forth the captives."

> Placed together on that plain, it was a marvellous sight to behold, for amongst them there were some of a reasonable degree of whiteness, handsome and well-made; others less white, resembling leopards in their colour; other as black as Ethiopians. . . . [S]ome had sunken cheeks, and their faces bathed in tears, looking at each other; others were groaning very dolorously, looking at the heights of the heavens, fixing their eyes upon them, crying out loudly . . . others struck their faces with their hands, throwing themselves on the earth. . . . [Now] came those who had the charge of the distribution, and they began to put them apart one from the other . . . to part children and parents, husbands and wives, and brethren from each other. . . . [T]he mothers enclosed their children in their arms and threw themselves with them on the ground, receiving wounds with little pity for their own flesh so that their children might not be torn from them! And so, with labour and difficulty, they concluded the partition.[13]

Zurara, moved by the suffering of the captives, comforted himself by reflecting that they were still better off than before, when they had lived in "damnation of souls . . . like animals." Now, he concludes, they are "dressed . . . fed . . . loved and turned with good will to the path of the Faith." Their captivity had brought them into a Christian land where they would hear the Gospel; this was all to the good.[14]

By 1452, the trade in slaves and other African goods had grown so fast ("yearly 3,500 slaves and more," the geographer Duarte Pacheco Pereira wrote, some decades later, "many tusks of elephant ivory, gold, fine cotton cloth and much other merchandise") that the king of Portugal decided to protect his country's interests in Africa by appealing to the pope.[15]

Young Afonso V had finally come of age four years before, forcing his uncle and regent Peter of Coimbra to give up control of the government; when Peter tried to fight back, Afonso's troops defeated him in a pitched battle at the river Alfarrobeira, during which Peter was struck through the heart with an arrow.[16]

Now in control of his own throne, Afonso V confirmed his uncle Henry's